Surjit Singh Barnala in Sangrur. This time, he entered the House with a smaller, representative sword.

Mann also dedicated his victory to the late, politically resonant rappers Deep Sidhu and Sidhu Moosewala—both of whom died young and whose last rites attracted nearly half a million mourners. The evening before the polls, Moosewala's last song, 'SYL', had been released on YouTube. The song glorifies terrorist Balwinder Singh Jatana, who allegedly killed chief engineer M.L. Sikri in 1990 to stop the construction of the Sutlej Yamuna Link (SYL) canal. AAP alleges that the song flared up local sentiments in favour of Mann. On June 26, YouTube pulled down the song in India, but the damage was probably done.

Since the 2014 general election, the panthic (rural religious Sikh) voters have gradually deserted their traditional habitat, the Sukhbir Badal-led Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD). In this bypoll, Badal had fielded Kamaldeep Kaur Rajoana—sister of convicted terrorist Balwant Singh Rajoana—to gain the sympathies of the radicals, but she lost her deposit, coming in fifth with 6.3 per cent votes. The bulk of the panthic voters had shifted from the Akali Dal to the Congress under Capt. Amarinder Singh and later to the Bhagwant Mann-led AAP in the state. Their main demand—among other long-standing issues—is justice in the Guru Granth Sahib desecration controversy of 2015 and the Kotkapura-Behbal Kalan police firing later during the protests against it.

Meanwhile, the three-month-old Bhagwant Mann government has had a rocky start. Apart from the law and order crises, the administration is being accused of being under the thumb of AAP chief and Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal. Political analyst Malwinder Singh Mali feels the verdict must have come as a rude awakening for the AAP leadership. "Punjab can't be governed from Delhi. The message is clear," he says.

As for Simranjit Mann, he built his campaign around a Punjab vs. Delhi battle, and now the issues that thrust Punjab into two decades of militancy—transfer of Chandigarh to Punjab, status of the SYL canal, along with the transfer of the Punjabi-speaking areas of Himachal and Haryana back to the state—could be back on the table. AAP leaders soft-pedalled on many of these issues during the assembly poll, but that ruse won't do now.

Back in 1995, after the reorganisation of the Akali Dal at the Moga convention, Simranjit Mann's faction cut ties with the refurbished outfit led by Parkash Singh Badal. The new Akali Dal had panthic stalwarts like Sukhdev Dhindsa, Surjit Singh Barnala, Gurcharan Singh Tohra, Jagdev Singh Talwandi, Ranjit Singh Brahmpura, among others. It called itself a secular, pan-Punjab party, and subsequently joined hands with the BJP and dominated Punjab's politics. Meanwhile, Simranjit's radical, separatist agenda gradually pushed him into oblivion in the state's politics. His victorious return now, when the Akali Dal is struggling, could put Mann in a position to reclaim the panthic leadership space.

Mann comes from a strong political family in Punjab—his father Joginder Singh Mann was a close associate of Akali Dal stalwart Master Tara Singh and speaker of the state assembly (1967-69). His wife Geetinder Kaur is the younger sister of Amarinder's wife and Congress MP from Patiala, Preneet Kaur.

In the run-up to the election, Mann remained unapologetic about his stand on Khalistan. He also has views on the SGPC (Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee), where he wants former terrorist Jagtar Singh Hawara as Akal Takht jathedar. Will the strident tone continue or will he mellow down for Parliament, in Punjab all eyes will be on Simranjit Mann, waiting for his next move. ■

It's the kind of bitter blow the Samajwadi Party would hardly have counted as a possibility. In a major setback, the Akhilesh Yadav-led party lost its bastions of Rampur and Azamgarh to the Bharatiya Janata Party on June 26 in byelections to both the Lok Sabha seats. The loss is significant, as the Azamgarh and Rampur seats were vacated by senior SP leader Azam Khan and Akhilesh himself after they won in the assembly polls in March.

BJP candidates Dinesh Lal Yadav 'Nirahua' (Azamgarh) and Ghanshyam Singh Lodhi (Rampur) defeated SP candidates Dharmendra Yadav and Asim Raja by margins of 8,679 and 42,192 votes, respectively. With these two seats gone, the SP has just three MPs in the Lok Sabha—an all-time low.

This loss also shows that the SP, the main opposition party in Uttar Pradesh, has been losing its hold over Muslims and Yadavs—their much-vaunted 'M-Y' support base. Muslims comprise over 40 per cent of the population in Rampur, while Muslims and Yadavs comprise above 30 per cent of the population in Azamgarh. Although SP leaders attributed the defeat to the "misuse of official machinery", a major section in the party are calling for a change in strategy. Some party functionaries are also raising questions about the absence of Akhilesh on the ground.

Indeed, the SP chief did not address a single public meeting and there is no clarity on why he stayed away in such crucial by-elections. Says a senior SP leader, "'The absence of Akhilesh*ji* from the campaign is one of the reasons behind the loss. If he had campaigned, the results would have been different. Dimple*ji* (Akhilesh's wife) also didn't campaign."

"Akhilesh*ji* was confident that the SP would win both seats even if he did not campaign....Our surveys showed